Hinges Without Mystery: A Reply to Wittgenstein's *On Certainty*

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1. Moore's Proof

Moore's proof of an external world begs the question. He holds up his hands, declares that here is one hand and here is another, and concludes that external objects exist. But the skeptic's challenge was precisely whether such declarations constitute knowledge. The skeptic can simply reply: you do not know that there is a hand there. Moore offers no reason to accept his premise that is not already a reason to reject skepticism, so the proof gives the skeptic nothing he is obliged to accept.

2. Wittgenstein's Response

In *On Certainty*, Wittgenstein agrees that Moore has not shown that he knows these things, but draws a different conclusion. Propositions such as "here is a hand" and "the earth has existed for many years" are not known, because knowledge belongs where evidence, checking, and doubt make sense. Instead, they are "hinges": the fixed framework within which evidence and doubt operate. On this view they are not known and they cannot coherently be doubted, because doubt itself presupposes them.

This is not an answer to the skeptic. It is a retreat. Wittgenstein does not explain how we know that there is a hand here. He concedes that we do not know it and then claims that we do not need to, reserving the language of knowledge for less basic beliefs. The skeptic's question is not answered; it is declared out of bounds.

3. Unreasonable Doubt Is Still Doubt

One can coherently doubt that there is a hand in front of one. One can coherently doubt that the earth has existed for more than a year. Such a doubter would be wrong, and would be unreasonable, but the doubt would be perfectly intelligible. We understand exactly what is being doubted and what it would take for the doubt to be correct.

Wittgenstein's position depends on conflating two things: doubt that is unreasonable and doubt that is unintelligible. That a doubt lacks good grounds makes it irrational, not meaningless. Once the two are separated, the special status of the hinges disappears, and the question becomes the ordinary one of why such doubts are unreasonable.

4. The Evidential Account

The reason such doubts are unreasonable is not that the beliefs form a transcendental framework, or that they are the banks through which the river of belief flows. The reason is evidential, in the ordinary sense.

Suppose I doubt that I am typing on a keyboard. If I treat my sense-perceptions as a dataset and try to explain them, the hypothesis that I am hallucinating leaves me with a great many anomalies. The hypothesis that I am not hallucinating, and that there is a keyboard, removes them. The external-world hypothesis is preferred for the same reason any well-supported theory is preferred: it accounts for the data far better than its rivals.

This also disposes of the claim that global doubt cannot use the evidential machinery it calls into question. The experiences themselves survive the doubt. Whatever their source, they remain data to be explained, and the question of which hypothesis explains them best remains open to ordinary assessment.

5. The Martian and the King

Imagine a being born with extreme and fully developed intelligence but with no empirical knowledge beyond what his short life has given him. He would not leap to the conclusion that the earth has existed for some particular length of time. He might not even be entirely sure about the hand. Nothing in the structure of thought forces these beliefs on him; he would have to arrive at them.

Wittgenstein considers a related case: a king raised to believe that the world began with him (§92). His treatment of it gives the game away. He says the king could be brought to the ordinary view only by persuasion, a kind of conversion, not by reasons. But this concedes that the hinges vary between people and communities, and so are contingent. A belief that one could fail to hold needs justification if it is to be held rationally. And the Martian, at least, would be brought around by reasons: geology, the travel time of light, rates of radioactive decay. “The earth is old” is a well-supported empirical conclusion, not a framework beyond discussion.

6. Continuity and the Status of the Explanation

Suppose the world is basically analogue, basically continuous. On that supposition I can explain why I see my hands when my eyes are open and not when they are closed: the hands persist while unobserved, so their reappearance is exactly what the hypothesis predicts. In the same way it explains the rest of experience, leaving aside Hume’s problem of induction. A continuous world allows one compact model to generate the whole stream of experience. A discontinuous or hallucinatory world has to stipulate each experience separately, which is not explanation but listing.

But this is merely an explanation. It is a good one, a reasonable one, and a correct one, but it is a hypothesis, defeasible in principle. That is no embarrassment. It is the status of all empirical knowledge. Continuity even goes partway toward the induction problem, since it licenses interpolation between observed states, though not extrapolation forward in time, which is where Hume’s problem remains.

7. Conclusion

Moore claimed certainty and gave no argument for it. Wittgenstein gave up on knowledge and claimed a certainty that lies outside argument. Both missed the right view: our basic beliefs about the world are knowledge without certainty, supported in the same way as any empirical theory, by being the best explanation of the data. What is true in *On Certainty* is psychological,

not epistemic. We do not consciously infer that we have hands. That is a fact about how these beliefs are acquired, and it does nothing to place them beyond evidence.